



near-unplayable. Adopting an intense counter-pressing style, the Oranje claimed a fourth successive Pro League crown, notching up 14 wins while losing just once in a shootout.

That pressing game has made it difficult for teams to break down its defence, which conceded just seven goals, 15 fewer than in the previous campaign.

Influential playmaker Xan de Waard, who is hanging up her stick at the end of the World Cup, will be instrumental to the pressing game. After a decorated career, she will have the opportunity to bow out in front of home supporters amid the Amstelveen summer, targeting a fourth World Cup crown.

In midfield partner Yibbi Jansen, the Dutch possess the most feared drag-flick specialist in the game. In the Pro League, she found the board 15 times from Penalty Corners, and opposition defences will need to work out a way to stop the Dutch's key threat.

Across the Netherlands' last three major competitions, only four teams have beaten it: Argentina, Belgium, India and Australia. Of those, only the South American and European nations managed to beat a near full-strength side.

Argentina's win came in the 2024-25 Pro League, after which it followed up with a second-place finish, then repeated that runner-up spot in 2025-26.

Defender Agustina Gorzelany (pic, left) will be the one to watch from set pieces. She is lethal with her drag-flicks, and her tally of 29 goals from set plays is second only to Jansen's 32 in the last two Pro League seasons.

Las Leonas are possibly the closest challengers to Dutch dominance. But after falling short against the Netherlands in the 2022 World Cup final and 2024 Olympics semifinal, they will know that their best might still not be enough.

Belgium, hosting the World Cup for the first time, will be another team to keep a close eye on. Under